

Charlotte Richard

3/19/25

Question 4: Scandal

Gustave Courbet and Edouard Manet both produced art during a time when the French art school, the Academy, defined the tradition of art and pushed back against their ideas with their works of realism, challenging the defined academic styles. While both *The Stonebreakers* by Courbet and *Olympia* by Manet resulted in controversy when presented at Paris Salons because of the unorthodox subject matter featured in their works, Courbet purposefully used scandal throughout his career to drive up his publicity while Manet's controversial subject matter resulted in negative reaction he did not necessarily intend.

The Stonebreakers (1849-50) by Courbet featured an unromanticized depiction of two working-class men on the side of the road, dressed in tattered clothing and crushing rocks. At 1.59 x 2.59 meters, it took up space when presented at the 1850 Paris Salon, where it was attacked as an un-artistic, socialist painting. However, Courbet created this piece with the intention of erupting in controversy; in a letter from Courbet to M. and Mme Francis Wey, along with detailing his inspiration for *The Stonebreakers*, Courbet claims, "For too long you have been making art that is pomaded and 'in good taste.' For too long painters, even my contemporaries, have based their art on ideas and stereotypes" (Chu, *The Letters of Gustave Courbet*, 88). Through this, Courbet acknowledges and embraces the standards he planned to shatter through his depiction of the "complete image of poverty" (88). Knowingly breaking the standards of Academy art with this depiction, Courbet stepped away from the 'good taste' of art of the time and unabashedly accepted the negativity that came along with this challenge.

Manet's *Olympia* (1865) also resulted in mass criticism when presented at the Salon of 1865. Featuring a naked woman, interpreted to be a prostitute by most viewers, the *Olympia* caused problems with the presentation of the subject. Nudes were common at the time and accepted by Academy standards, but only because of certain features that made them acceptable for high society that Manet's figure lacked. Her direct gaze, linear body, and the overall sensuality of this painting and her taboo line of work made it an unacceptable depiction of a naked woman, not a classical nude. This work was not Manet's first controversial female nude; in the Salon des Refusés of 1863 he presented *Le Déjeuner sur l'herbe* which sparked outrage because of the naked woman alone with three clothed men, causing onlookers at the time to jump to her role as a prostitute, making her unfit for a painting presented in public. Due to this reaction, he knew the negativity that came with this contentious subject matter, however he still remained optimistic and did not seek out the negative reaction as Courbet did. Talking about his upcoming work at the Salon in a letter to Baudelaire, Manet wished, "From the word I'm getting it actually seems their year won't go too badly." After the reaction to *Olympia* came out, he expressed sadness: "They are raining insults on me, I've never been led such a dance...all these cries have set me on edge, and it's clear that someone must be wrong" (Clark, *The Painting of Modern Life*, 82). Clearly Manet did not expect the controversy that arose from the presentation of *Olympia* – in fact, Manet believed himself to be in conversation with Titian's *Venus of Urbino*, but critics did not take this view. Due to *Olympia*'s perceived physical uncleanness, sexuality, complete nudity besides her hand, or just the fact that critics did not recognize Manet's attempt at conversation with Titian, he was not recognized for this, now clear, similarity.

The clear difference between Manet and Courbet was Courbet's use of controversy as a marketing strategy opposed to a consequence that came with creating meaningful work.

Courbet's controversy was the backbone of his career; Chu describes his marketing strategy by saying, "His marketing strategy was aimed simultaneously at gaining name recognition through controversy and at accommodating to a public demand for art that could enter comfortably into a mid-nineteenth-century middle-class home" (Chu, *The Most Arrogant Man in France*, 141).

Courbet embodied the motto 'any press is good press' and used the reaction he knew would come out of his controversial works to push his name to the general public and sell his smaller, less contentious works like landscapes, seascapes, and more appropriate female nudes. For Manet, controversy was a result of the subject matter of his paintings, not something that he sought out. While alive, it was hard for him to escape the reputation that came along with his creation of *Olympia*, which left him jaded and fleeing to Spain. Later, his entire collection was bought by Durand-Ruel, but he continued to submit paintings to the Salon although frequently rejected. While both artists faced similar controversy, Manet did not seek it out in the same way that Courbet continuously did throughout his career.

Courbet and Manet's attitudes toward publicity define their legacy today. Courbet's aptitude for scandal and his anti-establishment position allowed artists after him to use similar attention-grabs to spread their name. Tactics like Duchamp's fountain in the 20th-century and Damien Hirst's formaldehyde animals in 2008 are not all that different than Courbet's, challenging the standard of art and creating a public spectacle. Courbet started this form of publicity, with Chu claiming, "He had demonstrated that controversy need not be harmful to an

artist's reputation, as it was just another form of publicity" (Chu, *The Most Arrogant Man in France*, 174). Courbet became a model for artists to create this legacy of chaos and draw attention to their name in unconventional ways. Courbet struggled at the end of his career to sell his work because of overly radical political views with the Paris Commune, but his legacy as a pioneer of realism, almost too unafraid to cause a scandal, stayed with him through today. Differently, along with his reputation as a bridge between French Realism and early Impressionism, Manet is remembered positively for the same groundbreaking details in his work that salon-goers protested. His conversation with Titan is recognized and important to the context of his work, along with the challenge he placed upon the woman's place in society with her direct gaze, along with his ability to bring up taboos and challenge artistic norms of the time. His work is celebrated today because of the groundbreaking subject matter and style that was presented and unappreciated at the time. He did not attempt to seek publicity with the controversy, the publicity just came, and this is the critical difference between his and Courbet's scandals that is cemented in his legacy and the appreciation of *Olympia* today.

Question 3: Dealers

The commercialization of the art market in the 18th and 19th centuries brought art dealers to the center of the art scene, serving as a middleman between artists and art collectors. However, their role has naturally reflected throughout the changes in the art scene of the past 200 years, particularly when looking at the way they present themselves in relation to information surrounding art, the definition of art, and how they present and market the art they sell. When the Academy defined the standard of art, dealers used new methods of media promotion and presented themselves as experts in the field to sell their art. Throughout the era of impressionism,

the market shifted from the salon system to the system of the commercial dealers, and dealers had an active role in defining what was considered art through the pioneering of solo exhibitions. Today, dealers have less exclusive access to art because of the constant inflow of information in modern day, but still use tactics like public auctions to push forward their art.

The way the dealer presents art has evolved since the 18th-century. Gersaint was one of the first dealers to use marketing to sell his art, drawing attention to his shows and his business model. McClellan states, "Gersaint also imported two marketing tools-the public auction and the sale catalogue-that he raised to new levels of sophistication. He was the first, in France at least, to realize the potential of auctions, which he organized as a kind of public spectacle and which he promoted as events both instructive and amusing" (McClellan, *Watteau's Dealer*, 445). He saw the value in the media and drew attention to his art through public auctions and his iconic catalog. In the era of impressionism, auctions were not as prevalent, with the big development on the dealer's end being solo exhibitions. Durand-Ruel saw the success in putting on an exhibition exclusively featuring one artist and continued to spotlight success as a tactic for promotion. Vollard continued this trend, with exhibitions like his 1898 feature of Gauguin highlighting singular artists. Durand-Ruel used the press to his advantage, like Gersaint before him, investing "in marketing, placing several advertisements in the press" (Patry, *Inventing Impressionism*, 117). Dumas criticizes Vollard for his hasty exhibitions, as he was "notoriously blatant in his disregard for presentation" (Dumas, *Ambroise Vollard: Patron of the Avant-Garde*, 20). However, the solo exhibitions allowed dealers to pioneer a method of presentation that continued through today. In the modern day, dealers incorporate auctions and exhibitions into their presentation, with high involvement in the flashy public auctions. Dealers bid behind the scenes to manipulate prices of their auctions and auction houses like Christies' draw masses of attention to the sales of

art. This combines the original idea of the spectacle of auction, seen with Gersaint, with the modern evolution of media that defines all aspects of life. Art dealers relationship to presentation has evolved since the 18th-century, with auction going in and out while impressionist dealers pioneered solo exhibitions during their time.

Since the 18th century, art dealers have made themselves seem invaluable to the world of art by presenting themselves as experts in art, holding information others need them to access. In the 18th-century, Gersaint pioneered the catalog, listing items along with detailed descriptions, commentary, and historical context to market his art and the service he claimed to provide. This also turned into a form of curation, with his catalogs turning into the guide for what collectors should be buying. During the era of impressionism, Durand-Ruel and Vollard capitalized on the idea of curation and created solo exhibitions explicitly curated to best promote their artists. With the solo exhibitions, their role as a dealer was important particularly in discovering the artists and taking chances on the avant-garde, but they also worked with the artists to maximize success: “But rather than it appearing as if Durand-Ruel had taken over, the preparation, as well as the staging of these exhibitions, instead indicated a collaboration between the dealer and his painters” (Patry, *Inventing Impressionism*, 105). This era emphasized the dealer to hold the information to find and effectively present these artists, taking risky chances on up-and-coming artists to chance success. Today, dealers no longer have the same exclusive access to information. Regular people have access to the prices of comparable art through a simple Google search, allowing customers to regulate the prices and increase transparency but becoming another factor dealers have to consider when setting prices, no longer the gatekeepers of knowledge around art. The constant inflow of information today impacts every part of life, and the art market is no exception.

Dealers relation to the definition of art has evolved since the 18th-century. In the earlier periods, the Academy defined the standard of what was considered art. The second half of the 18th century began to evolve upon these ideas and dealers owned this attribution and began to credit themselves more with the success of art. “Lebrun boasted about his ability and experience as a connoisseur, and he emphasized his own role in the formation of significant collectors as much as the good taste of their owners” (452). After Gersaint, the involvement of the dealer in defining successful art became more normalized, and dealers became curators as opposed to distasteful middlemen. This evolution lasted through the 19th-century, with Durand-Ruel and Vollard becoming almost entrepreneurs with the standard of art, investing in pieces that challenged current standards but they saw potential to become successful art. One example of this is Durand-Ruel’s buyout of Manet’s collection – although Manet went against Academy standards, Durand-Ruel saw his potential success and used this to assert his confidence in his judgement around what could be considered art. Today, the easy access to media and conversation around art allows the collector to have a more active role in the definition of art, as opposed to it all coming from an Academy or all coming from dealers. Robert Pincus-Witten states: “The collector of contemporary art actually participates in the discourse of the day, adding through acquisition his or her particular inflection to this tumultuous conversation. Hence, the collecting of contemporary art - whatever other benefits it may provide or deficits it may incur - confers a voice upon the collector with regard to the formation of the larger culture and allows for a real participation in the actual events of the day” (Crow, *Artforum: Art and Its Markets*, 296). While dealers still help in creating this sensation of art and bringing artists publicity, people have more of a role in the greater definition of art. Dealers serve more on the business

side of the practice, as the practices of the art market continue to converge with the practices of a regular business model.

Globalization has greatly changed the art market, one development dealers must consider today which they did have to not consider during the 18th century and impressionist eras. In the past, dealers were celebrated for their international collections. In “Inventing Impressionism,” Zarobell credits Durand-Ruel’s business contacts in an international world with pushing his paintings into diverse eyes and promoting his business internationally. This international network was an advantage for him, not just showing his art to people in vicinity of his gallery but curating a larger network. Today, the globalization of art means that people across the world can be buying and viewing art at the touch of their fingers. This is a factor dealers must consider in the presentation of the work along with the accessibility of it. Globalization opens a market up to more players, allowing art to be sold on a wider scale along with an enhanced ability to buy and sell in real time. However, for dealers, this might be just as much of a burden as an advantage, because catering to this wider audience and dealing with the speed of buying and selling means they must adapt to the modernity of the art market.